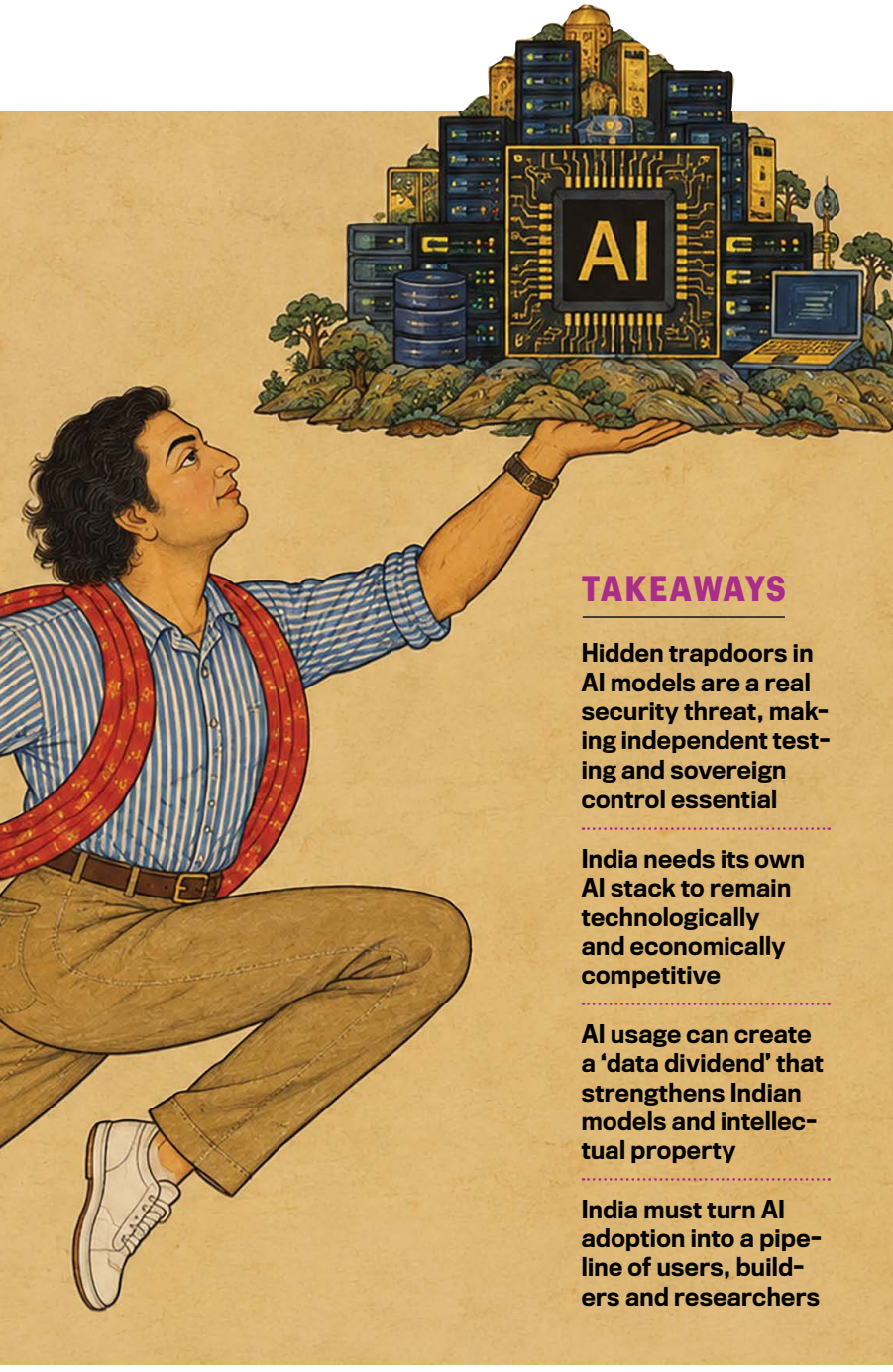


TAKEAWAYS

- **Hidden trapdoors in AI models are a real security threat, making independent testing and sovereign control essential**
- **India needs its own AI stack to remain technologically and economically competitive**
- **AI usage can create a 'data dividend' that strengthens Indian models and intellectual property**
- **India must turn AI adoption into a pipeline of users, builders and researchers**

people. The path runs from non-user to user, from user to builder and from builder to researcher. Useful applications give people their first practical experience of AI. Access to models, tools and training lets them build solutions to problems they know firsthand. Builders who hit the limits of existing systems need a route into research: computing access, mentorship and universities that welcome them.

Not everyone will travel the whole path—and no one will travel it by accident. The aim is to make the progression possible at scale. A professional spots a problem, a builder develops a solution and a researcher creates the capability that makes it reliable. When these contributions are connected, they give India a far broader foundation than mass consumption or a handful of elite laboratories could provide on their own.

Then there is security. Models used in defence, critical infrastructure and sensitive government work must face independent technical scrutiny because the threats are no longer hypothetical.

In 2025, researchers from Anthropic, the UK AI Security Institute and the Alan Turing Institute showed that as few as 250 'poisoned' documents could plant a backdoor in models of widely varying size. An earlier study found that deliberately trained hidden behaviours could stay dormant until triggered and survive standard safety training. None of this means every deployed model hides a trapdoor. It means no country should assume that one does not.

India, therefore, needs the expertise to understand model behaviour, examine training processes, hunt for hidden functionality and fix weaknesses. Keeping a model on Indian soil is not enough, and domestic ownership alone guarantees nothing. Large models are still hard to understand fully, which is exactly why sustained research and testing matter. Sovereign capability means having the access, people and infrastructure to judge risks independently, and to modify or replace a system when necessary.

These goals reinforce one another. Computing power supports both model development and security testing. Deployment generates evidence, evidence strengthens model IP, and stronger models produce more builders and researchers, who in turn build better models. Public investment should connect these pieces through shared infrastructure, research funding and competitive procurement. It should back several capable organisations, rather than one favourite, and hold all of them to clear standards of performance and security.

India should keep using excellent foreign technology. But it must also build the capacity to produce its own, turning adoption into learning, learning into model IP, and both into a growing pool of skilled people. That will take sustained investment and disciplined execution. The alternative is to remain a market for other nations' intelligence, when India could be a maker of it. ■

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